south of its High Street, a Mauryan establishment is described by the excavator as ‘House of the Guild’ because of the presence of a Mauryan seal-die inscribed with a legend mentioning a guild (‘Sahijitiye nigamasa’).[38] Even where no such inscribed objects have been recovered, inferences have been made on the basis of the particular types of objects and structures found. The ‘priest house’ at Daimabad in mid-first millennium BCE Maharashtra is known to have contained fire altars of various shapes; in the phase following, houses like those of the lime maker, the potter, and the bead maker were similarly identified.[39] The occupations of those in Taxilan houses have not been ascertained with this degree of assurance.

But it is possible to reconstruct the uses to which some of the rooms in Taxila’s houses were put. There are bathrooms and kitchens, and in chamber 15 of House K one can imagine clothes and utensils getting cleaned and hung: a soak-well and the remains of some rough stone flooring, as also large water jars found close by, support the inference. Soak-wells are basically vertical pits. In Taxila these were either stone-lined, or constructed of earthenware rings, or of large earthenware storage jars set up one above the other with holes in their bottoms to allow percolation. These were not for drawing water but were maintained in every house for sewage and waste household water. Logically, the rooms in which they were located were either kitchens or bathrooms or privies. In several such rooms the soak-wells are found in pairs, close to each other, and the ‘explanation of this may be that when one well was full, it was closed in and a new one opened alongside. Or it may be that they were intended to be used alternately, one being left to dry while the other was in use.’[40] Soak-wells were also placed in courtyards, so washing and scouring happened there as well. The usual wells, though, used for drawing water, are missing from the city. There was a functional reason for this. The height of the Bhir plateau made it impractical to dig wells. They would have had to be very